

The Hollow Crown of Vehl

a series in ten books

BOOK I

The Eighth Ash

— Chapter Five —

CHAPTER V

The City With Its Lights Still On

He had not, in his old life, been carried.

He was being carried now. He had agreed to it, on the principle that arguing the geometry of his small new legs against the geometry of a flight of stairs they could not yet climb was a waste of one of the two finite resources he possessed this evening, and the resource was time. The other resource was the woman who had picked him up.

She had picked him up with one hand. She had picked him up with the careful indifferent strength of a woman who had spent some years lifting heavier things than imps, and she had set him on the slope of her left shoulder with the back of his small body against the rope of her silver braid, and she had then, without comment, brought up her left hand and held him there as one would hold a small cat that had not yet decided

whether to leap. The hand was cold. The braid was warm. Her shoulder was the warmest thing he had touched on this side of dying.

He had decided, in the first ten seconds of being carried, not to think about that.

He had decided this on actuarial grounds. He was thirty-one years old in the head and approximately six hours old in the body, and the body had not yet finished assembling its catalog of pleasant sensations, and the small revisionary instinct that had been adjusting his sense of self all evening was in danger, in the warmth of the strange woman's shoulder, of revising it in a direction he had not approved. He set it down. He did not think about it. He kept the data point on file for review at a later date, after sleep, if there turned out to be sleep on this side of dying.

He thought, instead, about the corridor.

Sera Ilyne Vasquaire walked through it the way a woman walks who has walked it before. He had

registered this, in the first turning of the second stair, with the small precise pleasure of confirming a model. She had not, in her note, said how she had come into the complex. She had not, in the chapel two minutes ago, said how she would leave it. She had walked, however, with the easy turning of a woman whose feet remembered. There were, in the wall to their left as they climbed, three small marks the size of a thumbnail at regular intervals; Sera, without looking, brushed each one with the pad of her thumb as they passed, the way a woman might tap the railing of a familiar staircase to make sure it was still where she remembered. The marks, when Kael turned the small attention of his Debt-Sight onto them, glowed very faintly in the same cool blue as the writing on the floor of the reliquary. They were sigils. They had been laid into the wall by someone who knew the wall would be re-passed. They had been laid, he was reasonably certain, by Sera.

He thought: she has done this before. She has done this perhaps several times. She has done this perhaps over years.

He thought: she had two years to prepare for tonight. She used some of that time to seed a route.

He filed this, and did not say it aloud.

She was, he was learning in the first three minutes of being carried by her, a woman who did not appreciate her conclusions being read out before she had finished arranging them. He had said one sentence to her in the chapel — *I am at one Hunger. I am at Stage One.* — and he had watched her absorb the sentence and adjust the entire ladder of her plan around it without saying a word, and he had decided then that the way to be useful to her was to say only what she had not yet seen for herself. He had been read to in a thousand meetings by junior analysts who narrated obvious things at him while a senior partner steamed in the corner. He had become, over the nine years of his old

career, the senior partner. He understood the value of silence in a room with a fast mind.

He gave Sera the silence.

She used it. She walked the corridor at a pace that was just slow enough that Aren Mosk could keep up. The cultist trailed five feet behind, with the book against his chest and the water-skin against his back and the bitten heel of his left hand held inside the fold of his sleeve. He was no longer crying. He was, Kael had noticed without comment, breathing through his nose for the first time in three hours. His grey eyes had begun to track Sera's back with the careful attention of a man who, having spent a long time being afraid of one thing, was now reorganizing his fear around the corrected hierarchy of threats.

Sera said, after the second turning, "He will lose the use of that hand."

It was the first sentence she had spoken since they had left the chapel. Her voice was low and slightly hoarse,

the voice of a woman who had not used it for human conversation in some time. The hoarseness was, Kael decided after a half-second, not affected. It was the voice of a person who had been reading aloud, alone, in cold rooms, for years.

He turned his small head against her braid. "The bitten one."

"Yes."

"It is a clean bite."

"It is the bite of a creature that did not exist this morning. The body knows that. The body will close around it and then open again. There will be an infection that no surgeon on the surface knows how to read. He will keep the hand for three weeks. He will not keep the use of it."

Kael considered this. "You can read the bite at five paces."

"I can read it at fifty."

"Then your eyes are better than the Ledger's."

"On certain narrow questions. Yes." A small pause.

"Most of my work has been narrow questions."

He thought about that. He let himself, for the second time in five minutes, hear something Sera had said about her own work that he had not yet asked for. He registered, with a low careful gratitude, that she had decided to volunteer it. He thought: she is auditioning, too. We are auditioning each other.

He said, "Can the hand be kept."

A small pause, this one longer. They were on the third stair now, narrower, the steps high and uneven. Sera's right hand, the ungloved one, was held out very slightly from her body in a way Kael had seen people do when they were navigating a known dark place: fingers spread, ready to brush a wall. The braid moved against his shoulder as she breathed.

"It could be kept," she said, "if I had a Tallymark or two willing to do the work, a circle drawn properly, four hours, and a saint's tooth. I have none of these things tonight. The hand will heal as a hand that has been touched by you. The man will live."

"Will he be useful."

"To you, yes. To me, no. He has not had what I would call a useful life, but he has had one, and the difference between the life he has had and the life he is about to have is the difference your bite has made. Your bite has changed him. He will know what you are now in a way he did not know it before. He will know it in the bones of his bitten hand."

Kael said, after a moment, "Did I make a mistake."

"Asking him for the blood."

"Yes."

"No."

"I had two options. I had taking, and I had asking. The room would have permitted taking."

"The room would have permitted it. The Ledger would not have."

He went still. "Explain."

Sera Ilyne Vasquaire turned, very slightly, her face on the stair so that her cold-water eye was nearer his small wrong one, and she said, quietly:

"The Ledger you have been speaking with is not a complete Ledger, Kael Veyne. It is the dead Lord's. It is the institutional memory of a dead king's accounting. It is competent. It is older than anything you have ever held a conversation with. It is not, however, an arbiter of right action. It will tell you which transactions are available to you. It will not tell you which transactions will cost you something the transaction itself cannot price. The cost of taking from Aren Mosk would not have appeared on the Ledger tonight. It would have appeared on it eight months from now, on a different

page, in a different ink, when you found yourself in a room with the next person you wished to ask something of, and discovered that the small habit you formed by taking instead of asking had become, by then, a structural feature of how you handle the asking of things. You would have noticed it as a slight thickening in the muscle of your forearm. You would have noticed it as the absence of a hesitation that used to be there. You would have read it, by then, as efficiency. The Ledger, asked, would have said *yes, efficient*. The Ledger would have been right."

She paused for one stair.

"The thing that asked Aren Mosk for his blood tonight was not the Ledger. It was you."

She faced forward again.

Kael held very still against the rope of her braid. He had not been spoken to, in his old life, by a person who had read him this closely. He had been managed. He had been negotiated with. He had been, on certain

occasions, complimented by superiors who had used his outputs to file their own promotions. He had not been *read*. Sera Ilyne Vasquaire had read him in two sentences with the same cold professional ease with which she had read the sigils on the wall of the staircase, and the reading had been correct.

He thought about the small click he had felt in his chest when he had heard her name in the chapel.

He filed it.

He said, after a moment, "Thank you."

He had not said *thank you* on this side of dying yet. The small chittering wrong voice tripped on the second word — the wrong vowel for the small wrong tongue — but it came out, and Sera, walking, made a small low sound that he interpreted on instinct as a smile.

"You are welcome, Eighth."

"My name is Kael Veyne."

"I know. I am going to call you Eighth for a little while longer."

"Why."

"Because the men who are looking for you tonight do not know that you have a name. They know that you are the Eighth. If I call you by your name and they are listening, they will know that someone is in the catacombs with you, and they will know that the someone knows you. I will call you Eighth in the corridors. I will call you Kael in rooms with doors that close."

He understood this. He approved of it.

"How many doors that close," he said, "do you have for me."

A small pause. "Tonight. Three."

"Tell me about the first."

"The first is two flights above us. It is a wine cellar that belongs to a vintner who used to be a Tallymark and who agreed, eleven months ago, to forget where his cellar door is for a fee that I paid in advance. We will pass through the cellar. We will not stop. If we stop in the cellar, the vintner will hear us, because the vintner has not, despite my fee, stopped paying attention to his cellar; he is a careful man. We will be in the cellar for forty-one seconds."

"You have timed it."

"I have walked it four times."

"In daylight."

"At night. The vintner sleeps in the upstairs apartment. The cellar door is at the back of his kitchen. I have left a small thing in the kitchen on three of the four walks; it is still there on the fourth. He has not noticed."

Kael thought about that.

"What is the small thing."

"A coin. I leave it on his windowsill. It is a habit. I will retrieve it on the way past tonight."

Kael said, very dry, "You like the vintner."

"I do."

He filed this also. He had begun, in the last five sentences, to develop a working picture of Sera Ilyne Vasquaire as a woman who left coins on the windowsills of vintners she did not intend to rob, and who had once written *needful* in a note to a creature she had not yet met. He set the picture down beside the picture of the woman who had read his ribs at fifty paces, and he noted with a small private satisfaction that the two pictures did not contradict.

"Tell me about the second."

"The second door is at the top of the cellar stairs. It opens into an alley. The alley is empty between the third and fourth bells of the night. We will be in the alley between the fourth and fifth. The alley will not be

empty. There is a woman who sleeps under the lee of the bakery wall there; her name is Iva, she is mostly blind, she has been there for six years, the bakery feeds her by an arrangement I have not inquired into, and she is afraid of nothing because she has nothing left to lose. She is also, by accident, on my route. We will pass her. She will hear you, because her ears are very good. She will assume you are a cat I am carrying. I have, at her windowsill, also left a coin."

"Iva."

"Yes."

"And the third door."

"Is harder."

"Tell me anyway."

Sera walked four more steps before she answered.

"The third door is the gate at the foot of Cobbler's Lift. Cobbler's Lift is the staircase that climbs from the

harbor district up into the Lantern Quarter. The Lantern Quarter is where I live. The gate is guarded between the fifth bell and dawn by two men from the Watch. They are not, as a rule, attentive guards. They are attentive to people coming down out of the Lantern Quarter, because the Quarter is wealthier than the harbor and the merchants who employ the Watch have asked them to be alert to thieves descending. They are less attentive to people coming up. They will, however, look. I am not, by any reading, a person who passes notice. I am usually permitted to pass on my errands. Tonight I will be permitted to pass on my errand, because I am known. I am, however, not permitted to be carrying a small purple animal."

"Then I am to be a coat."

"Then you are to be a coat."

"Or a hat."

"Hats do not have tails. We have not yet had time to discuss what to do about your tail."

Kael lifted the tail off her shoulder, where it had been lying along the line of her braid, and curled it once, neatly, around his own small left wrist. He held it there. He looked at it. The tail, which had begun the evening as a thought he had not finished, was beginning to be a sentence he was learning to use.

"It will fit," he said, "inside my coat."

"It will."

"Then I am a coat with a hidden bookmark."

A very small breath of a sound from Sera. It was, this time, almost certainly a laugh.

They climbed.

The corridor opened, after the third turning, into a low cellar. Kael could smell the cellar before he saw it: wine, yes, but also the dry mineral cold of stone that had been kept cold by deliberate design for many years. He had been smelling nothing for hours, and the sudden presence of an honest scent — the leathery old

breath of cured oak and the pepper-and-mushroom under-note of red wine that had been stored well — was startling enough that for a moment his small new lungs forgot the cadence of their breathing. He took in the smell. He let himself, for the second time in five minutes, register a thing on this side of dying that was not data. He filed the registration.

Sera walked the cellar in twenty-seven of the forty-one seconds. She walked it without looking left or right, because she did not need to; she had walked it four times. She walked past racks of bottles laid head-to-foot in their cradles, past a small unlit lamp on a barrel, past a wooden door with a worn brass plate that read in a script Kael could not read but the Ledger could, *cellar of Halven of Mire-Stairs, vintner of the third bridge*. She walked through that door. She walked up the stairs on the other side of it. She walked into a kitchen.

In the kitchen, on the windowsill, there was a single small copper coin.

She picked it up. She put it in a pocket of her cloak.

She did not, Kael noticed with a small low warmth, slow her step to do it. She was a woman who did not break stride to honor her own private observances; she had built the observances into the stride.

She crossed the kitchen. She opened a back door. The bell of the fourth hour of the night was just then beginning, somewhere in the city, a low double note that fell across the rooftops with the unhurried courtesy of an old man clearing his throat. She slipped through the back door. Aren Mosk slipped through it after her. Kael, on her shoulder, slipped through it with her.

The alley.

He had been waiting, without entirely knowing he had been waiting, to see the sky.

The sky was not what he had expected.

He had expected the sky of his old world, with which his old world's stars; he had expected, against the small

private corner of his mind he was not yet ready to admit to, the wet grey sky of a Tokyo evening before rain. The sky above the alley was none of these things. It was a deep ink-blue that was not quite night, not quite anything else; it was lit, in the south, by what he understood after a moment to be the slow milk-pale glow of a moon that had not yet risen but was already, somehow, present in the upper air. The stars were wrong. He had time, in the four seconds it took Sera to take three strides down the alley, to register that the stars were arranged in patterns he could not read, and that there were more of them than there should have been, and that one of them — high and west and very, very faint — was the same precise cool blue as the Ledger.

He thought about that star later.

Now, he registered it and let it go, because the alley was narrow and Sera was walking quickly and there was, against the lee of the bakery wall to their right, a small huddled shape under a canvas.

Iva.

She was awake. Kael saw, in the candle-color of his Debt-Sight, the small bright glow at the canvas where two open eyes were turned in their direction. She had heard them. She had heard them, he understood, the moment they had stepped out of the kitchen door.

She did not speak.

She lifted one hand from under the canvas — a small old hand, the fingers very thin — and she made, in the air, a small specific shape with two fingers extended and the others curled. It was a sign. Kael did not know the sign. He felt, beside his head, Sera answer it with a small almost-imperceptible nod of her own.

They passed.

Five paces past the bakery wall, Sera said softly, without turning her head, "She gives the all-clear hand."

"She knows you."

"She has known me, in a manner of speaking, for three of the six years she has slept on this stretch. We have an arrangement that has nothing to do with money. I bring her, twice a season, a thing she asks me to find. She tells me, when I pass, whether there are people on the Lift tonight who are not the usual people."

"And tonight."

"Tonight there are. She gave the small variation. There is one extra man on the Lift."

"From the Watch."

"No. She would have used a different shape for a Watchman."

"Then."

A pause. Sera walked four more steps. The alley turned. They came out into a wider street, a paved street with the smell of seawater rising from somewhere below them on the right and the smell of woodsmoke coming from somewhere above them on

the left, and Kael understood, looking down the wider street, that the city of Tannev-on-the-Shoal was built on the side of a hill. Lights were on in windows. Not many. It was past the fourth bell of the night, and most of the windows were dark, but on the long curve of the street where it bent up the hill there were lamps lit at intervals on tall iron poles, and the lamps were not flames, and the lamps were not oil — they were small clear glass globes with the same steady cold blue light he had seen in the reliquary, hanging in the air at the top of each pole, no chain to a wick, no fuel, no flicker. The lanterns of the Lantern Quarter, he thought, naming the thing as it named itself. The light did not glow on the cobbles below them. The light glowed upward, and lit only the eaves of the houses on the upper side of the street.

It was the most beautiful thing he had seen in two worlds.

He set the registration down beside the others.

"Then who," he said, quietly, to Sera.

She walked four more steps. She said, very low:

"The extra man is one of the cult. He has been instructed, I think, to watch the foot of the Lift for the next several nights. He was not at the foot of the Lift two nights ago. He is at the foot of the Lift tonight. The Brother has decided that if you escape the catacombs, you will try to leave the city through the most obvious gate, and he has arranged for someone to be standing at the most obvious gate. He has, in this, correctly guessed half of the geometry."

"What is the other half."

"That I would meet you in the catacombs. He has not guessed that. He believes you are alone."

"And the man at the foot of the Lift."

"Is not, individually, a problem. He is a problem only because if I am seen carrying anything unusual past him, he will report it, and the report will reach the

Brother before dawn. I would prefer the report not reach the Brother before dawn."

Kael considered this.

"How long," he said, "before the report would otherwise reach the Brother."

"He will know by the third bell of tomorrow that the chamber failed. He will know by the fifth bell that the seven ran. He will know by the seventh that the eighth — that you — were not killed. He will, I think, send the more capable of his agents to the city by the ninth. We have, in essence, a day. Possibly a day and a half. Less, if the man at the foot of the Lift sees me carrying a coat with a tail."

"Then I will not have a tail."

"You will. I cannot ask you not to."

"I will arrange," Kael said, "not to have a tail. For forty seconds. I think the Ledger and I can manage forty seconds of tail-discipline between us."

Sera made the small low sound again.

The Ledger ticked, behind his attention, with what he had begun to read as quiet approval.

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TAIL ARTICULATION (locked) – develop:  
condition met (sustained voluntary  
retraction, 40 seconds, in service of  
a planned action).
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Faculty 'Tail Articulation' unlocking:  
condition 1 of 1 (intentional use).
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next pull of Hunger:  available.
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He looked at the line.

He understood what it was telling him.

He had, this evening, spent his Hunger only once — at the bite, in the reliquary, with Aren Mosk. The Hunger had refilled itself, slightly, in the long climb. He could, now, with the small reservoir he had, pay the cost of a fully active faculty: not a locked one, not a passive one, but a working tool. He had been holding the Tail-Articulation in reserve all evening, because the

Ledger had marked it locked. The Ledger was, now, offering to unlock it. The cost would be small. The benefit was — he saw, immediately — a tail he could think with. Not a tail that had opinions. A tail that obeyed.

He thought: yes.

He spent the Hunger.

He felt, in his small new chest, a brief warm sensation he had not felt before — a sense of a small ledger-line moving from one column to another in a transaction that took, in actual time, perhaps half a second. The tail around his wrist responded. It was no longer a sentence he was learning. It was a word he could say. He could feel its segments the way he could feel his fingers, individually, and he understood, with a small unfussy pleasure, that the body had begun, in some small way, to be his.

He curled the tail tightly along his left flank. He tucked it inside the line of Sera's cloak where it brushed against

him. He could feel the tail there, neatly furled, no longer drifting.

"I have a tail-discipline," he said to Sera.

"I noticed."

She crossed the street.

The foot of Cobbler's Lift was perhaps two hundred paces up the curve of the hill. The Lift was, Kael saw as they approached, a long steep staircase cut into the side of the hill with iron railings on either side and small cool blue lanterns set at every third step. There was an iron gate at its foot, opened inward. There were two men of the Watch leaning against the wall just to the right of the gate, in dark uniforms, their swords loosely belted. There was a third man standing fifteen paces to the left of the gate, not in a uniform, his hands in the pockets of a dark coat that did not match the cut of the city. He was not making any pretense of not watching. He was watching everyone who came up the street, and he was watching them with the slow attentive

boredom of a man who had been told to expect something interesting and had not yet seen it.

Sera adjusted, very slightly, the way she carried Kael. She tucked his small folded form deeper into the inside of her cloak. She drew the cloak more closely across her chest with her left hand, which freed her right. She kept walking.

She did not, Kael noted, slow.

She walked up to the gate the way a woman walks who has walked through it five hundred times. She nodded to the nearer of the two Watchmen. She said, in a voice that was perfectly normal — neither warm nor cold, neither casual nor pointed — "Bren."

"Lady Sera," the Watchman said. He did not, Kael saw, look at her cloak. He looked at her face and then, immediately, at the road behind her, which was the look of a man whose attention had been bought by years of small ordinary courtesies and was no longer for sale to small ordinary suspicions.

The second Watchman said nothing. He was younger. He did look at her cloak. He looked at the front of it, where the fold was. His eyes moved over the fold the way a child's eye moves over a wrapped parcel on a holiday morning. Then his eye moved up to her face, and saw what the older man had seen and not bothered to look for, and Kael, watching from inside the fold, registered the moment at which the younger Watchman decided that whatever was inside Lady Sera's cloak tonight was a thing he had not been paid enough to ask about. The young Watchman stepped back. He returned, with a small visible relief, to his bored station.

The third man — the one in the dark coat, the one not of the Watch — turned his head.

He did not move from his place. He turned his head, very slowly, and he looked at Sera, and Kael felt, against his small chest where it was pressed against the warmth of her, the woman tense in the precise economical way a person tenses who has decided not

to acknowledge that she has been seen.

She kept walking.

She walked through the gate. She took the first step of Cobbler's Lift. She took the second.

The third man, behind them, did not call out. He did not move. Kael, twisting his small head very slightly against Sera's collarbone, looked back through the slit of the cloak.

The man was watching them go.

He had a thin face and a clean-shaven jaw and a mouth that was set in the small flat line of a person who had been told what to watch for and was, in this moment, not certain whether what he was watching had been it. He had not moved. He had not called. He was waiting.

He was waiting because he was not sure.

Kael understood this with the same instinct that had told him to put the book on the pedestal in the reliquary. The man had been told to look for a small purple animal. The man had seen a woman walking up the Lift with a cloak that bulged slightly at the chest. The man had not yet decided what to do with the discrepancy. The man would, in the next ninety seconds, make a decision. The decision would either be *that was nothing* or it would be *that requires a second look*. The man's decision would, on the simple physics of the situation, be informed by what Sera did next.

What Sera did next was: she kept walking up the Lift, at the same pace, without speeding up.

Kael, against her chest, understood why. To speed up was to confirm. To walk away at the same indifferent pace was to refuse the confirmation. The man could not, on the basis of a slightly bulged cloak, leave his post and follow her up Cobbler's Lift; his orders were to watch the foot. To leave the post was to violate the orders. To violate the orders was to admit that the

slightly bulged cloak had warranted attention, which was to confirm what he could not, yet, confirm. He would not move.

He did not move.

They climbed seventy steps. They climbed a hundred. The cool blue lanterns at the third-step intervals passed under them and up around them and were behind them, and Kael felt the warmth of Sera's collarbone against the small wrong shoulder of the small wrong body and the cold of the night air on the back of his small ear, and he understood, with a clarity that was unwelcome and entirely outside his control, that he had not been this safe since he had stood on the landing between the fourth and fifth floors of his apartment building and heard a child laugh.

He set the registration down.

He filed it with the others.

At the top of the Lift, Sera paused. She did not turn around. She drew a slow even breath. Aren Mosk, behind her on the steps, drew several less even ones; he had not, evidently, expected the man at the foot of the Lift to let them pass, and was discovering, in the small landing at the top, that his body had been preparing for a confrontation that had not arrived. He sat down on the iron railing. He held the book against his chest. He worked his bitten left hand inside the fold of his sleeve.

Sera did not look at him.

She looked, instead, out across the Lantern Quarter. The Quarter was, in the night, a low spread of red-tiled rooftops descending in irregular terraces toward a low stone wall that defined the upper edge of the city. Above the wall, the hill continued in scrub and tussock for perhaps another half-mile, and then dropped, in a long pale fall of cliff, toward what Kael understood after a moment was the sea. He could hear it now. He could smell it. It was the smell of his old world's sea, only

colder; it had the same iodine under-note, the same low salt patience, the same impossible age.

He had not, until he heard it, known that he would miss the sea.

He looked away from it. He looked at the rooftops. He looked at the cool blue lanterns set, here and there, on the corners of the houses, and he understood for the first time why this part of the city was the Lantern Quarter and the other part was not. The lanterns were not a luxury. They were a marker. The blue light pooled, in the open windows here and there, in the same precise hue as the writing in his Ledger. The houses of the Lantern Quarter were houses that had, in their walls or their hearths or the windowsills where their tenants left coins for vintners, the small private installations of people who were on speaking terms with the same kind of accounting Kael was on speaking terms with.

It was, he thought, a neighborhood of Tallymen.

Sera said, very quietly, "We are here."

She turned, and she carried him along a short crooked street, past three doors that had small marks at thumbnail height on the lintels, to a fourth door that did not. The fourth door was painted a deep blackened green. It had a small brass knocker shaped like a fish. There was no other ornament.

Sera set Kael, very gently, down on the step.

She knelt. The knee of her riding-skirt brushed the cobble. She was, eye to eye with him on the step, taller than he was even kneeling — he came perhaps to her chin — and the cold-water eyes considered him without the small pity that had been in them in the chapel.

"Kael Veyne," she said, "I am going to open this door. The room on the other side is mine. I have not had anyone in it for two years. If you come in, you come in on terms I have not yet had time to say aloud. The terms are not punitive. They are practical. The first of them is that you are not, in this room or any room in this

Quarter, to refer to me by the third initial of my name in writing or in speech. The second is that you are not, ever, to ask me how I came to know what I know about your kind. I will tell you when I am ready to tell you. I am not ready tonight. The third is that you are to do, in this house, the thing you started in the reliquary."

He looked up at her.

"The asking instead of the taking."

"Yes."

"For the duration."

"For the duration."

"I accept."

"Then welcome, Eighth."

She opened the door.

Behind them, on the small landing at the top of Cobbler's Lift, Aren Mosk stood up unsteadily from the

iron railing. He held the book against his chest. He looked at the deep blackened-green door, and at the woman with silver hair kneeling on its step in front of a small purple creature he had helped to summon, and he understood — with the clarity that had been arriving in him all night in waves — that he had walked, by some long sequence of small decisions made by other people, into a life he had not chosen and could not now leave.

He came up to the step. He waited.

Sera turned her head. She looked at him for one long even second.

"Aren Mosk," she said, "I have a cot in the back room. You will sleep on it tonight. You will not, tonight, ask me where you are. You will not, tonight, ask anyone for anything. In the morning we will discuss the terms under which you will continue to be a person in this city."

Aren Mosk, for a moment, did not move.

Then he nodded.

He stepped through the door.

Kael followed him on his small thin legs, walking now, no longer carried, the tail furled neatly along his side. Sera closed the door behind them. The street outside the deep-green door was quiet. The blue lanterns at the corners hummed in the small private way the lanterns of Tannev-on-the-Shoal hummed in the small hours, and far below the Quarter, at the foot of Cobbler's Lift, a man in a dark coat that did not match the cut of the city stood, after some thought, and walked at last toward the harbor with a small unease he had not entirely earned the right to and was, all the same, going to have to take to his master before dawn.

In the warm dark of Sera Ilyne Vasquaire's house, the Ledger, behind Kael's small new eye, ticked one quiet line.

Stage 1 evolution conditions:

1. survive your summoning ✓
2. settle one outstanding room-debt ✓
3. take willingly given blood ✓
4. cross a city wall under recognition ✓
5. be admitted, by ask not by force,
into a sealed habitation ✓

condition 5 of 5 met.

Stage 2 unlock window: OPEN.

Stage 2 unlock cost: 1 Hunger.

Stage 2 form: Cinder-Imp.

confirm advancement? Y / N

Kael Veyne, Candidate the Eighth, eighteen inches tall in a house he had been admitted into by ask not by force, sat down on the warm wood of the floor of the front hall and read the line *confirm advancement* twice, and then a third time, and then he did the only thing he had learned, in his old life and in his six new hours, to do when a transaction of this consequence was offered him without warning.

He thought, with the small clean cold pleasure of a man who had spent his life refusing to be hurried by

counterparties: *No. Not yet.*

The Ledger, after the smallest possible pause,
accepted the answer.

It set the window down.

It did not close it.

It left it open, like a kept seat at a table the dealer had
not yet called, and behind his small new ear it added —
quietly, as though to itself —

*Wise, Eighth. The first stage is the one you choose.
The next one will choose you.*

— end of Chapter Five —